“Grieving shows a lack of faith.”

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Where it often comes from

Some Christians are told to “be strong,” “rejoice, they are in a better place,” or “don’t cry.” Those words may come from love, but they can leave mourners feeling that tears are a spiritual failure. We then grieve privately or pretend to be fine.

What Scripture teaches

“Jesus wept.” He wept at Lazarus’s tomb, knowing He was about to raise him. Isaiah describes the Messiah as “a man of sorrows, acquainted with grief.” Jesus said, “Blessed are those who mourn, for they will be comforted.” Solomon wrote, “A time to weep and a time to laugh.” Paul says we do not “grieve like the rest, who are without hope,” which does not mean that we do not grieve. The psalmist says that God keeps our tears. Tears and trust are not opposites. Deep grief often reflects deep love.

> *“Jesus wept”* (John 11:35).

Also see

> “Blessed are those who mourn, for they will be comforted” (Matthew 5:4).

> “Brothers, we do not want you to be uninformed about those who sleep in death, so that you will not grieve like the rest, who are without hope” (1 Thessalonians 4:13).

> “You have taken account of my wanderings. Put my tears in Your bottle— are they not in Your book?” (Psalm 56:8).

> “He was despised and rejected by men, a man of sorrows, acquainted with grief. Like one from whom men hide their faces, He was despised, and we esteemed Him not” (Isaiah 53:3).

Common self-statements

- Strong believers do not cry this much.
- If I really trusted God, I would be at peace.
- My tears show I doubt.
- I should be rejoicing, not mourning.
- People will think my faith is weak.
- I am letting God down.

Common logical errors

- Should statements: Insisting that I should not grieve.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing faith and sorrow cannot coexist.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling sad and concluding that my faith is lacking.
- Mind reading: Assuming others judge my tears.

Challenging questions

- Did Jesus grieve? What does that tell me?
- Who told me that grief is a lack of faith?
- What does “grieve with hope” mean?

- Can I trust God and cry at the same time?
- What do my tears say about my love?
- Who can I grieve with honestly?

Truth summary

> Grief does not show a lack of faith. Jesus wept, and He blesses those who mourn. I can grieve with hope, cry honestly, and trust God at the same time.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Grief
- Sorrow
- Death/Dying
- Faith
- Suffering

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Grief
- Suffering

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Just Be Held — Casting Crowns
God's care remains when control, strength, or explanations run out.

The God Who Stays — Matthew West
God's faithful presence challenges the expectation of rejection and abandonment.

Broken Things — Matthew West
God can work through imperfect people without waiting for them to become flawless.

Softly and Tenderly — Kristyn Getty with Vince Gill, Ellie Holcomb and Sierra Hull
This older hymn pictures Christ's gracious invitation to return rather than hide in shame.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

My Plan for Replacing "Grieving shows a lack of faith"

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"Grieving shows a lack of faith." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ Did Jesus grieve?
- ☐ Who told me grief is weak faith?
- ☐ What does hope mean?
- ☐ Can I trust and cry?
- ☐ Who can grieve with me?
- ☐ What psalm fits me?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ Jesus wept.
- ☐ Blessed are those who mourn.
- ☐ I grieve with hope.
- ☐ God keeps my tears.
- ☐ Tears reflect love.
- ☐ Faith and sorrow can live together.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ John 11:35
  "Jesus wept."
- ☐ Matthew 5:4
  "Blessed are those who mourn, for they will be comforted."
- ☐ Psalm 56:8
  "You have taken account of my wanderings. Put my tears in Your bottle— are they not in Your book?"

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] Tears and trust: Each week, note one time you cried and one time you trusted God in the sorrow.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, John 11:35 becomes: "Sarah can write: "Jesus wept, so my tears do not mean a lack of faith.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Grief" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- [ ] Read John 11. Notice that Jesus wept before He acted.
- [ ] Allow tears. Let yourself cry without apology.
- [ ] Find an honest friend. Share your grief with someone who does not rush you.
- [ ] Pray the Psalms. Pray Psalm 56:8 and others that voice sorrow.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "Grieving shows a lack of faith": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	Tears and trust
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~Grieving shows a lack of faith.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Jesus, You wept. Thank You that tears are not failure. Meet me in my sorrow, give me honest friends, and hold me in hope. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.